Topic 8 — Post-Mauryan India

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Post-Mauryan Period | Satavahana Rulers | South Indian History | Indo-Greeks | Shakas | Parthians | Kushanas | Kanishka | Sangam Age

Sources baked in: Hathigumpha, Ayodhya, Junagadh, Nasik, Sangam corpus, Ghatnachakra Post-Mauryan Period + South India (Sangam / Chola / Pallava / Chalukya), UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025, UKPCS (Ashvaghosa; empire outside India; gold–silver 1:35; Matsya Purana Andhra list) **Weight:** ★★★ — 2023 invader order, 2025 south-dynasty match, 2021 Satavahana, 2018 Hathigumpha + Ayodhya **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — static

Books and Writers — Post-Mauryan Age

Book–writer pairs | book → writer | Shunga / Satavahana / Kushan / Sangam

Book / text	Writer / authority	Horizon / use
Mahabhashya (महाभाष्य)	**Patanjali** (पतंजलि)	Shunga-age grammar; **not** Kanishka's court
Malavikagnimitra (मालविकाग्निमित्रम्)	**Kalidasa** (कालिदास)	Play on Agnimitra (अग्निमित्र) (Pushyamitra's son); Shunga setting
Gatha Saptasati	**Hala**	Prakrit anthology; Satavahana court
Milinda Panha	Dialogue of **Menander (Milinda)** and **Nagasena**	Indo-Greek Buddhist Q&A
Buddhacharita	**Ashvaghosha**	Buddha's life epic; Kanishka age
Saundarananda	**Ashvaghosha**	Same court circle
Sariputraprakarana	**Ashvaghosha**	Same court circle
Tolkappiyam	Tolkappiyar tradition	Earliest Tamil grammar and poetics; Sangam age
Silappadikaram	**Ilango Adigal**	Kannagi–Kovalan epic; later Sangam edge
Manimekalai (மணிமேகலை)	**Sattanar** (सत्तनार)	Buddhist sequel to Silappadikaram
Tirukkural (*Kural* / Muppal)	**Tiruvalluvar**	Called Laghuveda / Bible of Tamil ethics
Ramavataram	**Kamban**	Tamil Ramayana (later medieval Tamil classic)
Periplus of the Erythraean Sea	**Anonymous** Greek merchant	Red Sea / Indian Ocean trade handbook; Poduke = Arikamedu

Book / text	Writer / authority	Horizon / use
Matsya Purana	Puranic tradition	Longest Andhra / Satavahana king list (~30)
Vayu Purana	Puranic tradition	Kanva end / Andhra founder memory

- **Patanjali** belongs to the **Shunga** (शुंग) horizon. Do not put him in Kanishka's court.
- **Ashvaghosha** belongs to **Kanishka**. Do not put him with Ashoka.
- The *Periplus* has **no named author**.

> **Logic:** *Milinda Panha* monk = **Nagasena**, not Nagarjuna.

8.1 Post-Mauryan Period

185 BCE to Gupta rise ~320 CE | Magadha after the Mauryas | no single pan-Indian empire

After **185 BCE** India has several power centres at once. Magadha passes to the **Shungas**. The Deccan has the **Satavahanas**. The deep south has the Sangam **Muvendar**. The northwest door sees Indo-Greeks, then Shakas, then Parthians, then Kushans.

Pushyamitra Shunga coup (185 BCE) — Cause, Course, Result

Victim: last Mauryan **Brihadratha** | **Actor:** Mauryan general **Pushyamitra Shunga**

Cause: The Mauryan empire had weakened after **Ashoka**. The last king **Brihadratha** could not hold the army or the treasury.

Course: General **Pushyamitra Shunga** killed **Brihadratha** at a military review and seized Magadha. Buddhist tradition is hostile to him, but **Sanchi** (सांची) still grew in this age.

Result: The **Mauryan empire ended** in **185 BCE**. The **Shunga dynasty** ruled Magadha until **73 BCE**. Pushyamitra performed **two ashwamedhas**, recorded at **Ayodhya** — not Besnagar or Hathigumpha.

How the northwest order is remembered

- Match-lists often use the short trio **Greeks** → **Sakas** → **Kushans**.
- **Parthians** sit between Shakas and Kushans in fuller teaching. Papers sometimes drop them.

Shunga house (185–73 BCE)

- The capital is **Magadha** (मगध). **Vidisha** (विदिशा) is a second centre. Coaching memory also ties Shunga ancestry to **Ujjain** (उज्जैन).
- There is a Brahmanical revival under this house.
- Pushyamitra performs two **ashwamedha** rites. The **Ayodhya inscription** of **Dhanadeva** records those two.
- Do not place those ashvamedhas at Besnagar, Hathigumpha, or Sarnath.
- **Agnimitra** (अग्निमित्र) is Pushyamitra's son. Kalidasa's (कालिदास) *Malavikagnimitra* (मालविकाग्निमित्रम्) uses him.

- **Patanjali** of the *Mahabhashya* is placed in this court in tradition. He is **not** a Kanishka-court scholar.
- Buddhist books are hostile, yet Sanchi is still enlarged in this age.
- **Bharhut** (भरहुत) stupa railings are a classic **Shunga** sculpture fact.
- The last Shunga **Devabhuti** is killed by **Vasudeva Kanva**.

Kanva house (73–28 BCE)

- The Kanvas are a short Magadha house after the Shungas.
- Puranic memory says the last Kanva **Susharma** falls to an Andhra / Satavahana founder (**Simuka**).
- After that, the north is open to later local and foreign powers.

Two inscriptions not to swap

- Kharavela's **Hathigumpha** is the Kalinga card. It is not Pushyamitra's ashvamedha record.
- **Heliodorus** at Besnagar is a Bhagavata Greek ambassador. He is also not the ashvamedha record.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q91]: Hathigumpha inscription** of Kharavela on Udayagiri hills (Odisha) records 14 years of Kharavela's reign; 5th year records canal diversion from Tan-suliya. *(See Q6 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** 185 = Shunga coup, not Ashoka's death (232).

8.2 Satavahana Rulers

Deccan / Andhra house | ~1st c. BCE–3rd c. CE | Puranic "Andhras"

- The founder in tradition is **Simuka** (also Sindhuk / Shipraka in Puranas). Capitals are **Pratishthana (Paithan)** — the lasting capital — and early **Amaravati**. The title **Dakshinapathapati** (दक्षिणापथपति) means lord of the southern path. Names are often **metronymic**: Gautamiputra, Vashishthiputra.
- The **Matsya Purana** gives the longest Andhra / Satavahana king list (about **30** names).
- **Hala** (17th ruler) was a poet-king and patron of literature who authored the celebrated Prakrit erotic anthology **Gathasaptasati (Sattasai)**; his contemporary **Gunadhya** composed the lost epic **Brihatkatha** in Paisachi Prakrit.
- **Satakarni I** is the early expansion king and the first to hold the title **Satakarni**. The **Naneghat** inscription of queen **Naganika** belongs to this house.
- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** is the greatest.

Gautamiputra Satakarni vs Nahapana — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Shaka **Nahapana** (Kshaharata) controlled a belt from **Ajmer** to **Nasik** and threatened Satavahana survival. **Course: Gautamiputra Satakarni** defeated Nahapana. The **Nasik prasasti** of **Gautami Balashri** records the victory. Nahapana's silver was restruck. The same record calls him **Ekabrahmana** and protector of the **varna** (वर्ण) order (no free intermixture of the four varnas). **Result:** Satavahana power peaked in the western Deccan. Later Shaka greatness passed to the **Kardamaka** house of **Rudradaman** (रुद्रदामन). He restruck Nahapana's silver (Jogalthembi hoard type).

Ruler	Fact
Simuka	Traditional founder after Kanva Susharma
Satakarni I	Early expansion; **Naneghat** of queen **Naganika**
Gautamiputra Satakarni	Greatest; defeats **Nahapana**; **Ekabrahmana** / varna protector; **Nasik** of **Gautami Balashri**
Vashishthiputra Pulumavi	Son and successor
Hala	*Gatha Saptasati* in Prakrit
Yajna Sri Satakarni	**Ship** on coins — sea-trade fact

- They nurtured **Prakrit** in inscriptions and *gathas*, not Sanskrit as the court speech. **Public art** got more push: the **Amaravati** stupa (with **Ayaka / Aryaka pillars**), the **Karle** (कार्ले) chaitya, and the Nasik caves.
- Coin metals: punch-marked, **lead**, copper, bronze, silver, potin — **not gold**.
- Land grants to Brahmans and Buddhist monks start to show. Roman trade crosses their roads. Decline comes about the 3rd century CE. **Ikshvakus** at Nagarjunakonda come next in Andhra. **Vakatakas** (founder **Vindhyashakti**) rise in the Deccan after Satavahana weakening.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2021, Q52]:** Satavahanas were called **Andhra-Bhrityas** in Puranas; Prakrit was their official administrative language; maternal naming tradition (Gautamiputra) but patrilineal succession. *(See Q4 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** Gautamiputra Satakarni = **Satavahana** (सातवाहन) (Paithan). Kanishka = **Kushan**. Madurai = **Pandya**.

8.2a Ikshvakus and Nagarjunakonda

- After Satavahana decline (~3rd century CE), the **Ikshvakus** ruled coastal **Andhra** from **Nagarjunakonda**.
- The site is famous for **Buddhist stupa**, monastery, and **Ikshvaku inscriptions**.
- Puranas call them **Shriparvatiya**. Ikshvakus here are a **post-Satavahana Andhra** house. The mythic Ayodhya Ikshvaku line is a separate Puranic genealogy.

8.3 South Indian History

Peninsula below the Vindhyas | Kalinga under Kharavela | megalithic south | Sangam Tamilakam

This card covers three south layers. First comes **Kharavela** of Kalinga. Then come Iron Age **megaliths**. Then Ashoka's RE II names the Tamil neighbours who stay independent.

Kharavela — Hathigumpha Campaigns (Cause, Course, Result)

Source: Hathigumpha inscription, Udayagiri | **Dynasty:** Mahameghavahana / Chedi | **Religion:** Jain

Cause: Kalinga sought independence, trade prestige, and recovery of cult images after Nanda and Mauryan pressure.

Course: The inscription records recovery of a **Jina image** carried off by a **Nanda** king. It also records military expeditions toward **Magadha** and the **south**, plus gifts to monks and public works.

Result: Kharavela is the strongest **post-Mauryan Kalinga** ruler in epigraphy. **Hathigumpha** = Kharavela.

Kharavela — identity facts

- The source is the **Hathigumpha** inscription at **Udayagiri** (उदयगिरि), Odisha.
- **Hathigumpha** belongs to **Kharavela** of Kalinga. Ashoka, Harsha, and Kanishka have **other** inscriptions.
- He is a Jain patron.
- Caves stand at **Udayagiri (18)** and **Khandagiri (15)**.
- Hathigumpha itself is at **Udayagiri**, not Khandagiri.
- The dynasty label is **Mahameghavahana / Chedi**.

Megalithic south

- **Megalithic** cultures are Iron Age burial traditions of the peninsula and parts of central India.
- They predate and underlie the Sangam polities.
- Burial types include **dolmens**, **cists**, stone circles, capstones, and **hero stones (virakkal / nadukal)** for warriors.
- Pottery is often **black-and-red ware (BRW)**.
- Iron tools and weapons appear in the graves.
- Major sites include **Brahmagiri**, **Adichanallur**, **Maski**, **Hallur**, **Nevasa**, and **Piklihal**.
- Brahmagiri links megalithic layers to early historic transitions.
- **PGW** is Later Vedic **doab** (दोआब) ware. **Megaliths** are mainly **south and Deccan** Iron Age burials.
- Grave goods can include pottery, iron weapons, gold, and beads.
- Some sites show communal or family burials under large stone slabs.

Ashoka's southern neighbours

- Rock Edict **II** names Chola, Pandya, Keralaputra, and Satiyaputra as **independent neighbours**.
- They are **not** Mauryan provinces.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q16]: Kharavela** of Chedi/Mahameghavahana dynasty is the king recorded in Hathigumpha inscription. *(See Q5 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** Hathigumpha **=** Kharavela** of Kalinga.

8.3b Post-Mauryan Art Schools — Quick Compare

School	Period / patron	Material / style	Key fact
Gandhara	Kushan northwest	Greco-Buddhist **green schist**	Greco-Roman Buddha face; Indo-Greek bridge
Mathura	Kushan / local	Red sandstone Indian types	Indigenous Buddha forms
Amaravati	Satavahana Andhra	Limestone narrative reliefs	Andhra Buddhist stupa art
Karle / Nasik	Satavahana age	Rock-cut **chaitya** (चैत्य) halls	Public Buddhist architecture

8.4 Indo-Greeks

Bactrian Greeks in India | after Alexander's satraps | before Shakas

- Alexander's **326** march (Hydaspes, Sangala, Beas turn-back) belongs to the **Foreign Invasions** chapter. Indo-Greeks are the **later** Bactrian-Greek kings inside India.
- In chronology, "Greeks" means Alexander's wave **plus** these Indo-Greeks.
- They sit **before** Shakas and **before** Kushans.
- **Greco-Bactria** breaks from the Seleucids under **Diodotus**, about **250 BCE**. **Demetrius I**, about **180 BCE**, makes the first major push into India with an elephant-scalp helmet type.
- The greatest name is **Menander (Milinda)**. His capital is **Sagala (Sialkot)**. The *Milinda Panha* records his debate with **Nagasena**. He is **not** a contemporary of Bimbisara / Buddha / Prasenjit. Sixteen Menander coins are remembered from **Bairat**.
- **Agathocles** and **Pantaleon** issue early bilingual coins with **Brahmi** (ब्राह्मी) legends and **Sankarshana (Balarama) / Vasudeva** types. **Apollodotus** is an early Indian-side silver king.
- They issue the first **portrait**, die-struck coins in India. Legends are **Greek plus Kharoshthi**. Sometimes Brahmi appears. Late Indo-Greek **Strato II** is remembered for **lead** coins.
- **Heliodorus**, ambassador of **Antialcidas**, raises the **Besnagar** (Vidisha) Garuda pillar about **113 BCE**. He calls himself a Bhagavata of **Vasudeva**.
- The *Yuga Purana* memory places **Yavanas** toward **Pataliputra** (पाटलिपुत्र). That raid belongs to the Indo-Greek age, not to Alexander in 326 BCE.
- Besnagar is **not** Pushyamitra's two-ashwamedha record. That inscription is at **Ayodhya**.
- Indo-Greek power in the northwest ends when **Shakas** take Gandhara and Punjab.

> **Logic:** Menander = Indo-Greek, *Milinda Panha*, capital **Sagala**. **Sangala** = Alexander's 326 battle. **Heliodorus pillar** = **Besnagar**. Pushyamitra ashwamedha = **Ayodhya**.

8.5 Shakas

Indo-Scythians | after Greeks, before Kushans | title kshatrapa / mahakshatrapa

- The Indian name **Shaka** means **Scythian** nomads pushed from Central Asia into India from about the **1st century BCE**.
- The first king named in India is **Maues / Moga** at **Taxila** (तक्षशिला) and **Gandhara**. His capital tradition points to **Sirkap**. **Azes I** often follows in coin lists.
- The **Kshaharata** line rules in the western Deccan belt. **Bhumaka** is an early name. **Nahapana** is the greatest of this house.
- Nahapana's coins run from **Ajmer** to **Nasik**. His capital is **Minnagara**, between Ujjain and Broach.
- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** defeats Nahapana. The **Nasik prasasti** of **Gautami Balashri** records the victory. Nahapana's silver was restruck.
- The **Kardamaka** line rules western India from about the 1st century CE. **Chashtana** is the founder named in the **Andau inscription** of 130 CE.
- **Rudradaman I** is Chashtana's grandson and the greatest western Shaka. He rules about **130–150 CE** as **mahakshatrapa** (महाक्षत्रप).
- His **Junagadh / Girnar** inscription is the first long record in literary **Sanskrit** prose in India and the earliest specimen of **kavya** style on stone.
- The **Sudarshana lake** story sits on that rock. It was built by **Pushyagupta**, a Vaishya, under **Chandragupta Maurya**. It was adorned by **Tushaspha**, a Yavana, under **Ashoka**. A storm burst the embankment. **Rudradaman repaired it without forced labour**. He did **not** claim he founded the lake.
- Kardamaka coinage is mainly **silver** (रूपक) and **potin**; **copper** issues are rare.
- Western Shaka rule fades when **Rudrasimha III** is defeated by **Chandragupta II** (चंद्रगुप्त द्वितीय) in the 4th century CE.
- Coaching ratio for gold : silver in the Saka–Kshatrapa horizon is **1 : 35** (**UKPCS 2021**).
- **Vikrama Samvat 57 BCE** is the Vikramaditya legend at Ujjain. It is **not** the **Shaka era 78 CE** tied to Kanishka. The two eras differ by **135 years**.

> **Logic:** Junagadh is not Hathigumpha. Rudradaman is not Kharavela. Nahapana is Kshaharata, not Kardamaka.

8.6 Parthians

Pahlavas | brief northwest bridge | between Shaka west and Kushan rise

- The **Parthians** are called **Pahlavas** in Indian sources. They hold a **short** belt in the northwest after Shakas and before Kushan dominance.
- Their zone is **Gandhara**, **Punjab**, and **Sind** (सिंध).
- The best-known king is **Gondophares**, who rules about **19–45 CE**. His coins and inscriptions appear in the Kabul–Taxila belt.
- The site fact for Parthian-period Buddhism in the NW is **Takht-i-Bahi** near Mardan in Pakistan.

- Christian legend places **St Thomas** at Gondophares' court. That is tradition, not a royal inscription.
- **Kujula Kadphises** of the Kushans displaces Parthian and remaining Greek power in the northwest.

> **Logic:** Gondophares is **Parthian / Pahlava**. He is not Maues (Shaka) and not Kanishka (Kushan).

8.7 Kushanas

Yuezhi clan | 1st–3rd c. CE | Silk Road empire | last of the 2023 trio

- The **Kushanas** were one clan of the **Yuezhi** nomads of north Central Asia. They moved through Bactria into Gandhara and the Punjab.
- The founder is **Kujula Kadphises**. He unifies Yuezhi clans and takes Gandhara–Punjab. His coinage is mainly **copper**.
- **Vima Kadphises** (Kadphises II) issues the first large-scale **gold** coinage for regular use in India. Titles include **Shaonanoshao** (king of kings) and **Sarvalokeshvara**.
- **Kanishka** is the greatest Kushan ruler.
- **Huvishka** and **Vasudeva I** are later great names before decline.
- The main capital is **Purushapura (Peshawar)**. **Mathura** in Uttar Pradesh is the second great Kushan centre inside India.
- At its height the empire runs from the **Oxus** / Turfan fringe to the middle **Ganga** (गंगा) plain — a dynasty whose power also sat **outside** India.
- Coins are gold **dinaras** with legends in **Greek**, **Bactrian**, and **Kharoshthi** (खरोष्ठी). Royal portraits are standard. **Yaudheya** copper coins of this age show **Kartikeya** with a peacock.
- Kushan patronage pairs **Gandhara** Greco-Buddhist sculpture (**green schist**) with **Mathura** red-sandstone Indian types. **Bamiyan** held colossal rock-cut Buddhas in the Afghan Kushan world.
- Trade ran through the Persian Gulf and Red Sea (*Periplus of the Erythraean Sea* — **anonymous** Greek merchant; Arikamedu amphorae). Evidence does **not** support a strong Kushan **navy**.
- Social coaching note: **child marriage** custom is often dated from the Kushan age, with girls' upanayana fading.
- The Kushans are **last** in the 2023 invader trio: Greeks → Sakas → Kushans.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q23]:** Chronological order of invaders in ancient India: **Greeks (Indo-Greeks)** → **Sakas (Scythians)** → **Kushanas**. *(See Q2 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** Vima's gold ≠ Gupta dinara as a "first" if the paper wants Kushan gold.

8.8 Kanishka

Greatest Kushan | Purushapura | Shaka era 78 CE | Fourth Buddhist Council

- **Kanishka** is the most famous Kushan ruler. His empire included Afghanistan, Gandhara, Punjab, and much of the Ganga plain.

- keys usually peg his accession to **78 CE**, the start of the **Shaka Samvat** (Shaka era). Some books use about **127 CE** for his reign peak. Prelims still want **78 CE** when they say Shaka era. Vikrama **57 BCE** and Shaka **78 CE** differ by **135 years**. National calendar **Chaitra 1 ≈ 22 March** (21 March in a leap year).
- Kanishka uses the title **Devaputra** (son of god). The **Rabatak inscription** from Afghanistan gives his genealogy and names cities **Saketa, Kaushambi, Pataliputra, and Champa — not Shravasti**.
- The Sarnath Buddhist image inscription of Kanishka is dated about **81 CE** (year 3 of his era).
- Kanishka convenes the **Fourth Buddhist Council** in **Kashmir** at **Kundalvana / Kundalavana**.
- **Vasumitra** is remembered as president of the council. **Ashvaghosha** writes *Buddhacharita*, *Saundarananda*, and *Sariputraprakarana*. Court circle also remembers **Parsva**, **Nagarjuna**, and physician **Charaka**. **Patanjali** is **not** of this court (Shunga age).
- Chinese texts remember Kanishka's clash with **Pan Chao** (Ban Chao) and defeat of a large Kushan force.
- The school linked to the council is **Sarvastivada** (सर्वास्तिवाद). Mahayana Buddhism grows strongly under Kushan patronage.
- Council-king memory: **Ajatashatru** (अजातशत्रु) (1st), **Kalashoka** (2nd), **Ashoka** (3rd), **Kanishka** (4th).
- Kanishka builds a great stupa at **Peshawar**. Chinese pilgrims later describe it.
- His coins show **Buddha**, **Shiva**, **Mithra**, and Greek deities on the same series.
- Kanishka is a common **trap option** for **Hathigumpha**. That inscription belongs to **Kharavela** of Kalinga.

> **Logic:** Shaka era = **78 CE** (Kanishka). Vikrama era = **57 BCE**. **Hathigumpha** = **Kharavela** of Kalinga. Rabatak ≠ Shravasti.

8.9 Sangam Age

Tamilakam south of Krishna–Tungabhadra | ~300 BCE–300 CE | literature as the state archive

- **Sangam** (संगम) means a conference of poets or a forum of scholars. The literature composed in those assemblies is **Sangam literature**.
- The traditional seat is **Madurai** under the **Pandyas**.
- Sangam Tamilakam is **contemporary** with the Satavahanas — a **parallel** south, a different dynasty.
- Later legend counts **three Sangams**. The first two are largely mythical; the Third Sangam is the poems we still have.

Sangam	Place	President / tradition
First	**Madurai**	Saint **Agastya** (with **Tolkappiyar** in some lists)
Second	**Kapadapuram**	Saint **Agastya**
Third	**Madurai**	**Nakkirar**

- Sage **Agastya** is credited with having **Aryanised** south India. Tradition says he came south from **Kashi** (काशी) at the gods' request and later resided in the south. He is also called the **Father of Tamil Literature**.
- According to Sangam texts, the titles **Kon**, **Ko**, and **Mannan** belong to the **king**.
- **Ettuttokai** (எட்டுத்தொகை) is the eight anthologies (*Purananuru*, *Akananuru*). **Pattuppattu** (பத்துப்பாட்டு) is the ten long songs (*Pattinappalai* is the Puhar port poem).
- ***Tolkappiyam*** is the residual text of the Second Sangam tradition and the **most ancient available** long Tamil work. It is a treatise on **grammar and poetry**, written in a formula style. Author **Tolkappiyar** is counted among the **twelve disciples** of Agastya.
- ***Silappadikaram*** is by **Ilango Adigal**, remembered as a grandson of Chola **Karikala**. It narrates the tragic story of **Kannagi** and her husband **Kovalan**.
- ***Tirukkural*** (*Kural*) by **Tiruvalluvar** is called the Bible and **Laghuveda** of Tamil literature. It is also known as **Muppal**.
- ***Manimekalai*** by **Sattanar** is the Buddhist sequel to the Kannagi epic.
- ***Ramavataram*** (Tamil Ramayana) was authored by **Kamban** (later medieval Tamil; not a Third Sangam anthology, but a high-yield Tamil classic).
- **Akam** is inner / love poetry. **Puram** is outer / war and kingship.
- Five landscapes (*tinai*): **Kurinji** (hills, Murugan, hunting), **Mullai** (pastoral forest, cattle), **Marudam** (plains, paddy), **Neydal** (coast, fishing and salt), **Palai** (dry land, separation and raids).
- **Vattakirutal** in Sangam poems is a defeated king's **ritual suicide by starving himself to death**.

Kingdom	Emblem	Capital	Port	Famous king
Chera	Bow	**Vanji / Vanchi / Karur (Karuvur)**	**Muziris (Muchiri)**; also **Tondi**	**Senguttuvan**; **Udiyanjiral** (early Chera)
Chola	Tiger	**Uraiyur**	**Puhar / Kaveripattinam**	**Karikala**
Pandya	Fish	**Madurai**	**Korkai**	**Nedunjeliyan**

- **Karikala** builds the **Kallanai** (Grand Anicut) on the Kaveri and builds up Puhar. He is **not** Rajaraja I.
- **Uraiyur** on the Kaveri in Tiruchirappalli was also called **Koli** and **Varanam**. It was a major **cotton** centre and appears in the *Periplus of the Erythraean Sea*.
- **Udiyanjiral** belongs to the **Chera** dynasty and is often treated as the first historical Chera of the Sangam age.
- **Senguttuvan** sits on the west-coast Roman pepper trade. Later memory gives him the Pattini / Kannagi cult.
- The Pandyas hold the pearl coast at Korkai and patronise the Madurai assembly.
- Pandya country lies **south of the Kaveri**, centred on Madurai and parts of the far south. The river of that core is the **Vaigai**. Some question banks print **"Vengi"** for this Pandya river — do **not** confuse it with Eastern Chalukya **Vengi** on the Andhra coast.
- A **Pandya** king sent an ambassador to the kingdom of **Rome in 26 BCE**. The Pandya house has one of the longest remembered spans in the deep south, with capital at **Madurai**.

- The king is *vendan* (also Kon / Ko / Mannan). Land tax is **vari**. Customs are **sungam**. Units are **nadu** and **ur**. Sub-chiefs are **velir**. This is not a Mauryan kumara-mahamatra machine.
- Sangam literature describes the rise of **Chera, Chola, and Pandya** only. **Pallava** and **Kadamba** are **not** Sangam Muvendar houses.
- The anonymous Greek *Periplus of the Erythraean Sea* lists western ports such as **Naura**, **Tondi**, **Mushiri / Muziris**, and **Nelcynda / Nelisanda**.
- **Arikamedu** near Pondicherry is the foremost Indo–Roman station on the eastern coast. An intaglio identified with **Augustus Caesar**, plus beads and gems, support Roman contact. Dubreuil called it "a true Roman city." In the *Periplus* it is **Poduke**.
- An **amphora** is an ancient tall jar with a long narrow neck and **two handles**, used in Rome for wine or oil.
- Black pepper was a favourite of expensive Roman cookery. In Sanskrit it is ***Yavanapriya*** — "favourite of the Yavanas / Greeks."
- Trade guilds of later south-Indian townships include **Manigramam**, **Nanadesi** (नानादेशी), and **Valanjiyar**.
- **Keeladi** is early historic Tamil urban. Tamil-Brahmi appears on pottery and caves. Yavana in the poems means a foreign or Roman trader.

> **Logic:** Muvendar is not Pallava. Sangam texts are not the *Arthashastra* (अर्थशास्त्र). **Poduke = Arikamedu**. **Yavanapriya = pepper**, not muslin.

8.9a Sangam Wars and Inter-State Politics

Chera–Chola–Pandya rivalry | Puram war poems | not the later imperial Cholas

Sangam **Puram** poetry remembers constant wars among the **Muvendar** — **Chera**, **Chola**, and **Pandya**. These are early historic Tamil kings, not the later imperial Cholas of Rajaraja I.

Cause

- Three crowns competed for river land, ports, and prestige in Tamilakam.
- Hill and border **velir** chiefs fought under or against the great kings.

Course — named kings

- **Karikala** of the Cholas fought rivals and built the **Kallanai** dam on the Kaveri.
- **Nedunjeliyan** of the Pandyas appears in war poems such as the **Purananuru**.
- **Senguttuvan** of the Cheras is linked to the west-coast pepper trade.
- The same Chera house is tied to the **Kannagi / Pattini** legend in *Silappadikaram*.

Result / custom

- Victory brought tribute, cattle, and fame in Puram verse.

- When a king lost in battle, **Vattakirutal** could follow — ritual fasting unto death.
- Do not confuse Sangam Karikala with later **Rajaraja I**.

8.10 Later South — 2025 match only

Not Post-Mauryan meat | parked here because 2025 dumped it on a south-dynasty list

- **Mahendravarman I** is a **Pallava**. He belongs to the 7th century and to Mamallapuram. He wrote *Mattavilasa Prahasana* (मत्तविलास प्रहसन).
- **Kadungon** is a **Pandya**. He belongs to the 6th-century revival after the **Kalabhra** gap.
- **Amoghavarsha I** is a **Rashtrakuta**. He belongs to the 9th century at Manyakheta. He is linked to Kannada *Kavirajamarga*.
- **Rajaraja I** is a **Chola**. He rules **985–1014**. He builds **Brihadeshwara** at Thanjavur.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q121]:** Demetrius = Indo-Greek; Rudradaman = Saka; Gondophares = Parthian/Pahlava; Vim Kadphises = Kushan. *(See Q1 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** Rajaraja I is **not** a Sangam Chola. Karikala is.

UP Focus

Fact	Place
Ayodhya ashwamedha inscription	Ayodhya — Pushyamitra fact
Mathura	Kushan **second capital**. Mathura art
Sarnath	Not the Pushyamitra ashwamedha record
Deep-south Sangam	Not a UP polity. Ports are Tamilakam